

MIDTERM Assignment

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Governance, Elite Hegemony, and Gender Hierarchies: A Comparative Analysis of Monarchical and Non-Monarchical Systems in the Ancient World

What made the great empires of history endure, -fear of the ruler or faith in the system? Greek historian Thucydides reflected that true happiness arises from freedom, and freedom itself depends on courage, - an insight that captures how power and belief knitted-within the ancient world (Thucydides, 2009). Yet in the ancient world, freedom itself often depended on submission to power, a paradox that reveals how rulers sustained dominance not only by force, but through belief and consent. The ancient kingdoms of Assyria, Persia, and China and the non-monarchic republics of Athens and Rome built their political systems which, in spite of the institutional disparities, operated in strikingly similar ways of elite coercion and gender inequality. This analysis examines how monarchic empires established centralized hierarchies through divine authority and elite cooperation; how republics such as Athens and Rome maintained hegemony by distributing power among male citizens while concealing structural inequality; and how both forms of governance legitimized patriarchal hierarchies through ideology, demonstrating that the endurance of power in the ancient world rested less on coercion than on consent.

Firstly, this part discusses how ancient monarchic empires such as Assyria and Persia built power through hegemonic administrative systems rooted in elite cooperation rather than sheer military force. These empires sustained authority by negotiating loyalty through diplomacy and privilege, showing ‘that consent, more than conquest’ held their vast territories together. According to the Universal Empire reading with the Assyrian diplomatic materials, "Assyrian rulers exercised diplomacy before warfare, securing loyalty through treaties and rewards to local elites -an early form of hegemony built on consent rather than coercion" (Black, 2016, p. 95).

The Assyrian administrative system, especially in the Neo-Assyrian period, was based on the so-called flexible strategies of imperial governance according to which, in certain instances, the Assyrian Empire did not necessarily seek to impose a fixed and dogmatic grand project and, conversely, accommodated to the preexisting socio-ecological circumstances in the newly conquered regions to avoid the particularistic and centrifugal temptations (Palmisano 2023). This diplomatic playing between imperial power and local elites echoes subsequent imperial colonial patterns; see how British colonial Bengal also depended on local merchant classes to mediate between it, maintaining rule by privilege and collaboration instead of open revolt, a reminder of the persistence of imperial patterns of hegemonic strategies over millennia.

Moreover, this hegemonic strategy was recreated and further developed in the Persian Achaemenid administration with its well-known policy of religious and cultural toleration and the system of organized administrative subordination (Farazmand, 1998). As the empire continued to retain a centralized military and fiscal authority via its five-level organization system beginning with Great King to the satrapies to the district administrators, they had at the same time they accorded subject people astonishing freedom in local matters, with the traditional laws, religions and practices as long as they did not disrupt or conflict with the interests of the empire (Farazmand, 1998). As they travelled to the east into China, this ideology of the nominally all-powerful monarch who believed the inhabitants of All under Heaven were his subjects, ruled over an ostensibly meritocratic officialdom, and barely tolerated a few cases of institutional autonomy, was built (Pines, 2009). However, even such seemingly autocratic systems operated on the basis of hegemonic collaboration with the regional elites whose commitment to imperial ideology was the key to successful governance in huge regions.

In addition to this, comparison of these monarchies with non-monarchies shows that both Athens and Rome were also dependent on the collaboration of the hegemonic elites even though they had radically different constitutions. Concordia Ordinum is the term used by scholars to describe harmony between the estates which was reached by Roman Republic senatorial elites who preserved preponderant power and allowed limited concessions to plebeian assemblies (Black, 2016). The actual power of the republic was concentrated in the hands of the patricians; but this could not and would not be the permanent power. The plebeians, the majority of the army, and the real workers, revolted, going on strike and requesting equal representation in the government (Wasson, 2015). Mechanisms of elite-popular tensions that were developed out of the institutional innovations that came out of this Conflict of the Orders maintained the basic structures of elite dominance, which is a hegemonic response that made cooperation possible only with limited concessions as opposed to coercion by itself. Likewise, the Athenian democracy was characterized by the sharing of political power among the male citizens by participating directly in assemblies and juries, but the practical power was controlled by the rich, who had the means of education and rhetoric training, and the leisure needed to dominate the discussions inside the assembly (Black, 2016). What this tells us is that both monarchy and democracy were based on hegemony, convincing the elite and the citizens as well, to believe that their subjugation is natural, good, or ordained by God instead of using military strength to hold on. Now, when one looks back at these empires, it becomes evident that hegemony was less a political invention than a psychological condition. Its an instinct to consent when control is cloaked in legitimacy. Their endurance was built not on domination itself, but on understanding the minds of those being ruled.

Moving on, this part discusses how political and economic power in both monarchic and republican systems remained intense among elite men, revealing that hegemony operated

through deliberate exclusion of the poor and women. In monarchy, elite power rationalisation was achieved through planned co-optation tactics according to which kings formed linkages and bonds with the local nobility (Palmisano, 2023) and introduced provincial nobles into hierarchical patronage structures where their power depended on royal favour wholesomely. This trend was seen by the Persian administration which placed provincial governors in power in most cases belonging to the Persian nobility and who enjoyed extensive civil and judicial powers, but were still subject to elaborate checks and balances (Farazmand, 1998), making even apparently independent regional administrators be ultimately answerable to the Great King. In the Chinese context, although imperial ideology proclaimed meritocracy, in practice "provincial governors, military commanders, and high officials came overwhelmingly from noble or quasi-noble families" (Pines, 2009, p. 82). This demonstrates that even systems claiming to promote talent consistently favored established elites.

Moreover, the non-monarchical regimes of Rome and Athens had employed different but equally successful mechanisms of maintaining the dominance of elites as well as establishing the illusion of popular sovereignty. Only the Roman senatorial elite could stay in power thanks to patronage networks, family relationships, and control over prestigious magistracies even under the theologically sovereign popular assemblies (Black, 2016). Equally, the Athenian democracy gave men citizens direct access to assemblies and juries but was dominated by affluent landowners with the time, rhetorical education and cultural prestige to dominate the public debate.

> "Every male Athenian it was believed was a direct descendant of the demi-god Erichthonius. According to this myth, Erichthonius' parents were two of the city's major deities, Athena and Hephaestus, while this hero was born out of the earth herself. That

> every Athenian male had come from this divine birth was used by Athenian democracy to justify the political equality of every citizen" (Keuls, 2014, p. 175-176)

The Athenian democracy used the fact that all men in Athens were of this divine birth to explain why all citizens were politically equal, but this allegedly egalitarian civic mythology specifically excluded women, slaves, and foreigners, - about 70-80% of the population of Athens, who had no right to political participation at all.

Importantly, the analysis of the situation of poor masses and women helps understand common trends of marginalization regardless of the specific forms of politics. This inequality was clearly recognized by the Chinese political thinking: philosophers acknowledged the people as the core of the polity, whose welfare should be the primary concern of the policymakers, and whose sentiments should be always recognized, but could never consider any significant effort to enable them to express their complaints directly and otherwise affect the way of political activities (Pines, 2009). In Rome, assemblies of plebeians were permitted to vote on the law, but not to initiate law-making; a great number of successful senators could become prominent and control the political decision-making process (Black, 2016). Most civilizations denied women political participation of any kind irrespective of the type of government. The language and the law instituted the categorical differences in Athens that did not allow any involvement of a woman in governance institutions, in particular in Athens a woman was almost never referred to as a polites or a citizen, but as an aste, a woman of the city or an Attic wife (Keuls, 2014), which formed the basis of the language and the law. The Roman example is similar, and the women were denied citizenship, assemblies and places of the magistracy, though more wealthy Roman women sometimes had an informal power by means of family networks and management of the personal wealth which they inherited in the form of dowries.

Lastly, this part will illustrate how ideological beliefs, whether divine authority or civic virtue; legitimized hierarchy in monarchies and republics alike, transformed inequality into accepted social order. By persuading subjects and citizens that inequality was natural and moral, these belief systems turned domination into willing consent. In monarchies, concentrated power was legitimized by three ideologies that were intertwined namely divine selection of rulers, dynasties of hereditary elite and the need to unify geographically-politically to avoid anarchy. The Assyrian royal ideology explicitly asserted that kings were powerful as viceroyals of the god Assur, to legitimize their rule with the help of religious authority , and Persian Great Kings likewise legitimized their rule with the assistance of Ahura Mazda (Black, 2016). Chinese imperial ideology worked out the principle of the so-called Mandate of Heaven- the idea of so-called all-powerful king was valid in the epoch of Qin (221-207 BC) and Han (206 BC-220 CE) as well as in the late imperial dynasties (Pines, 2009). These ideologies clearly explained hereditary succession and centralization of decision-making through the presentation of the divinely chosen one as being uniquely fit to govern All under Heaven or the land governed by Assur. Moreover, royal ideology focused on the political unity as the key to peace and prosperity; Chinese intellectuals acknowledged the fact that the empire was not solely a military and administrative but also intellectual one, which was visualized and designed much earlier before it turned into reality , and unification was the means of ending the chaos and violence of warring states. Imperial consolidation was also a feature that the Assyrian and Persian expansion boasted to offer peace and unity to their disintegrated lands that were once marred by war (Pines, 2009).

On the other hand, non-monarchical systems worked out popular sovereignty ideology, liberty, and equality before the law as the sources of lawful rule. Athenian demokratia was founded on the principle that the power should be in the hands of the citizen body by direct participation in

the Assembly, voting of the laws directly, and the rule of law, instead of being left to the will of one ruler (Black, 2016). The Athenian ideology model specifically opposed monarchy, and it was clear that the Athenians did not support the idea of cancellation of debts or redistributing property through the state, but they strongly supported equal justice irrespective of wealth or position (Black, 2016). On the same note, Roman republican thought stressed the concept of the state res publica, or the affair of the people, which meant shared and constitutional government, in which absolute monarchy (regnum) could not coexist with republican principles (Black, 2016). The tribune became an institutionalization of this ideology, whose populist arguments stated that liberty was the highest political value...nothing could be more beautiful...you could say that they could only guarantee their liberty in a state where the sovereign was the people (Black, 2016).

However even with such deep ideological differences between monarchical divine mandate and non-monarchical popular sovereignty, the two systems served the same purpose of maintaining elite power by hegemonic mechanisms that turned coercion into consent. This shows the manner in which ideology itself was used to promote hegemonic consent, be it the religious or the principles of democracy, either of them were used to justify the accumulation of power into the hands of the elite. By legitimizing power without regard to divine authority, monarchical systems limited that power at the same time with maintaining operational modes quite vague, which allowed the Chinese empire to adapt to a vast number of domestic and foreign pressures; in other words, the creative tension between imperial ideology and operational ministerial authority (Pines, 2009). Although non-monarchical systems based their rule on the principles of popular rule, they set mechanisms to ensure elite rule: in Athens, rich citizens removed the highest offices and military leadership by high cultural education and rhetoric skill; in Rome, the senate sustained its rule by precedent, prestige, despite the hypothetical popular supremacy. Both

systems incorporated the systematic exclusion of women into their legal systems: Athenian law had placed restrictions on the legal capacity of women in its legal framework, it had denied them citizenship, and reduced them to the role of household managers under the constant guardianship of men; Roman law had similarly stipulated that women are constant charges in need of male protection. The fundamental assumptions of female nature justified the subordination of women in all societies...women were seen as lacking sophrosyne (moderation), incapable of restraining the appetites and desires of the body, and were described as gluttonous, extreme drinkers and nymphomaniacs whose sexual wantonness could weaken household legitimacy, whereas the notion of a monarchical system assumed male dominance without any extensive elaboration of the philosophical basis (Keuls, 2014). What this shows is that hegemony, a means of establishing dominance by consent, privilege, and ideological legitimization, operated a hundred miles apart in the politics of vastly disparate political regimes to ensure elite dominance by the patriarchal.

Glancing back over these empires and republics, it will be found that the fight between liberty and authority is not that old at all; it persists in all societies that identify order with equality. The moral of the ancient world will remain: to conquer, one must not only use arms but also faith, and faith, once obtained, is the most powerful source of power. The timeless fact is that the empire is living not by the sword but by the silent assumption that subordination is a part of nature. Maybe it is the reason why all ages, old and new, should ask themselves, whether their obedience is due to justice or to the silent satisfaction of the acceptance of something without protest.

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